

HOLOCAUST



BETWEEN 1939 AND 1945, six million European Jews were systematically murdered by the German Nazi regime. Some were killed in their own towns, but most

died in concentration camps. This mass murder of Jews is known

as the Holocaust, after a Biblical term meaning "slaughter by fire". It was a deliberate national policy established by Adolf Hitler and his Nazi followers to wipe out all traces of Jewish life and culture. Jews have been persecuted throughout history, but the Holocaust, which slaughtered nearly 70% of Europe's Jews, is history's worst example of anti-Semitism. Today, people still ask how such an atrocity was allowed to happen.

Concentration camps

Special concentration camps were built by the Nazis to detain people considered "undesirable", particularly Jews. From 1941, many camps were set up throughout eastern Europe, including Chelmno, Treblinka, and Auschwitz. These were literally death camps, built to achieve Hitler's "final solution" of exterminating all European Jews. Thousands of men, women, and children were led into chambers where they were killed with a cyanide compound, Zyklon B, introduced through vents in the walls. Non-Jews were also killed, including gypsies and the disabled.



Entrance to Auschwitz

Auschwitz

One of the most feared death camps was Auschwitz (Oświęcim) in Poland, where some 12,000 victims a day were gassed and their bodies cremated. It was this burning in the death camps that gave the Holocaust its name.



Death camps were in eastern Europe

Deportation

European Jews from France to Greece were rounded up, loaded onto trains, in cattle cars, and deported to death camps. local people hostile to Jews often helped the Nazis to do this. Up to a thousand people were forced into each train, and deprived of food and water. On arrival, survivors were sent to the gas chambers.

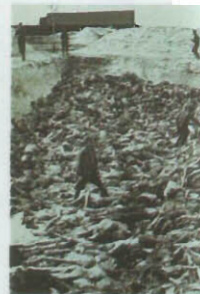
Jewish resistance

Despite the power of the Nazis, the Jews did resist oppression. During the war, there were revolts by Jews in ghettos, such as Warsaw, and even in the concentration camps, such as Sobibor. Elsewhere, small bands of Jews formed partisan groups that fought heroically in enemy territory, attacking Germans, and destroying military stores and railway tracks.



Liberation

From 1942, news of the death camps began to reach the West. It was only in 1945, however, that the full story emerged. When the Allied forces liberated the camps, they found, to their horror, huge mounds of skeletal people either dead or dying.



Timeline

1925 Adolf Hitler publishes *Mein Kampf* (My Struggle). In it, he states his anti-Semitism (hatred of Jews).

1933 Hitler becomes Chancellor and begins the persecution of German Jews. First camp is built at Dachau.

1935 Nuremberg Laws declare Jews to be second-class German citizens.

9–10 Nov 1938 "Kristallnacht" (Night of Broken Glass), Germany. People attack more than 7000 Jewish shops and homes, and 30,000 Jews are sent to concentration camps.

1941 Hitler, Eichmann, and other leading Nazis announce their "final solution". Death camps are set up throughout Europe for mass slaughter.

1943 Warsaw Ghetto Uprising. Nazis kill or deport more than 56,000 Jews in four weeks.

1945 Allied forces liberate concentration camp in Eastern Europe.

1962 First tree is planted in Israel's Avenue of the Righteous, which commemorates non-Jews who saved Jewish life during World War II.



Anne Frank

Born in Frankfurt, Anne Frank (1929–45) was a German Jew. In 1933, she and her family fled to Amsterdam, Holland, to escape persecution. In 1941, the Nazis invaded Holland, and from July 1942, Anne and her family were hidden by friends. While in hiding, she wrote a diary that is now world famous. In August 1944, the family was betrayed and sent to the concentration camps. Anne died in Bergen Belsen camp at the age of 16.

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